they were in the right place, and spent the next several minutes laughing with one another. Suddenly one of them pulled a grenade from his bag and threw it toward a table of patrons.[27] Several minutes of indiscriminate firing followed, during which time the gunmen stopped only to reload. After killing eleven people and wounding another twenty-eight the two left and ran toward the Taj Mahal Hotel located several hundred yards away.[28]

A Mumbai icon, the Taj Hotel has two wings: the Heritage Wing and the Taj Towers. At approximately the same time as the attack on the Leopold Café commenced, Hafiz Arshad [a.k.a. Abdul Rehman Bada or Hayaji] from Multan Road and Javed [a.k.a. Abu Ali] from Okara entered the main lobby of the Taj Hotel. The two opened fire immediately and indiscriminately, killing close to twenty people within the first few minutes.[29] The attackers from the Leopold arrived soon thereafter. The two teams linked up and together they moved to the sixth floor of the Heritage Wing. The terrorists at the Taj, as well as those who attacked the Trident-Oberoi and the Chabad House, were in touch with handlers in Pakistan via their own cell phones as well as those taken from hostages and victims. At the Taj, the fidayeen contacted Lashkar handlers in Pakistan as soon as the two teams had linked up. They were directed to start a fire immediately. Video shows that instead of doing so the fidayeen spent several minutes wandering around the luxury hotel in awe. During a follow-up call to check on the status of the fire, one of the Lashkar fidayeen responded with nonsequiturs about their palatial surroundings: ‘There are computers here with thirty inch screens’ and ‘The windows are huge. It’s got two kitchens, a bath and a little shop.’[30] Their Lashkar handler kept pushing for a fire, which was intended to propel potential hostages from their rooms. It would also draw media to the scene and make for great theater. One handler told the gunmen that the Taj was the most important target, and pictures of the iconic hotel engulfed in flames have since become an enduring image of the Mumbai attacks.[31]

As with the Trident-Oberoi and Chabad House, each discussed below, a hostage situation developed at the Taj. Most of the thirty-six people who were killed throughout the course of what became a three-day siege died during the initial onslaught.[32] Many guests locked themselves in their own or other people’s rooms; others hid along with hotel staff in common areas. The attackers phoned random hotel rooms to narrow their search, while